Research Brief: Maintenance Request Tool

A one-recommendation brief comparing three tools to replace maintenance requests sent by text message.

CLIENT	ROLE	TOOLS	RESEARCH DATE
Larkspur Property Co.	Remote VA	Google Docs	October 12, 2026

3
tools compared

$0
cost of the recommended plan

7
sources, each dated

< $50
monthly budget respected

THE SCENARIO

Dana's team tracks maintenance requests through text messages, and requests get lost. She wants a simple tool her five non-technical staff can use, for under $50 a month.

THE TASK

Find suitable tools, compare the best three on price, ease of use, features and limits, and recommend one, with the reasoning and sources included.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Summary and recommendation	p. 2
Comparison table and cost at team size	p. 2
What users say, next steps and sources	p. 3

WHAT IT SHOWS

- Recommendation first: a busy client gets the answer in the first paragraph
- Honest trade-offs: the recommended tool's main downside is stated up front
- Budget math worked out for the client's actual team size, including annual vs monthly billing
- Verifiable research: prices from official pricing pages and reviews from Capterra, all dated

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Maintenance Request Tool: Recommendation for Dana

Prepared October 12, 2026 (v2, with user reviews). All prices checked on the vendors' official pricing pages on October 12, 2026 (USD).

Summary and Recommendation

Recommendation: start on MaintainX's free Basic plan. It is built for maintenance requests, costs $0, and lets any number of staff submit requests at no charge. If the team outgrows it, the paid Essential plan still fits the budget for up to 2 paid users.

- **Why MaintainX:** Requests become trackable work orders with a status, an assignee and a history, instead of getting lost in a text thread. Staff who only report problems use free "requester" accounts, so the cost does not grow with the team.
- **Main downside:** The free plan only allows photos on 5 work orders per month. Photos are often the fastest way to explain a repair, so a busy month will push the team toward the paid plan ($20/user/month billed annually, or $25 monthly).
- **Runner-up:** Trello, if the team wants the simplest possible board and does not need maintenance-specific features.

Assumption to confirm: I assumed a team of about 5, where 1 to 2 people handle repairs and the rest only report issues. Paid plans charge per user, so if more people need to close out work orders, the budget math changes (see "Cost at your team size" below).

Comparison

Tool	Price	Ease of use	Key features	Limitations
MaintainX (Basic, free)	$0. Essential: $20/user/mo (annual) or $25 (monthly). Requesters free.	High. Mobile-first app; designed for frontline staff.	Unlimited work orders, unlimited requester users, real-time messaging, iOS/Android app.	Photos on only 5 work orders/month; 2 repeating work orders; 1 month of advanced analytics.
Trello (Free or Standard)	Free for up to 10 collaborators. Standard: $5/user/mo (annual) or $6 (monthly).	Very high. Drag-and-drop cards; little training needed.	Cards with assignees and due dates, mobile apps, 250 automation runs/mo (free), custom fields on Standard.	General task tool, not built for maintenance. Everyone submitting must be a board member; no asset or repair history.
UpKeep (Essential)	$24/user/mo. No free plan (free trial). Requesters free. Setup packages from $500.	High. Mobile-first CMMS.	Unlimited work orders and locations, free requester and view-only users, AI assistant credits.	Preventive maintenance and checklists only from Premium ($55/user). Over budget past 2 paid users.

Cost at Your Team Size

- **MaintainX:** $0 on Basic. On Essential, 2 paid users = $40/mo (annual) or $50/mo (monthly). Monthly billing sits exactly at the $50 limit, so annual billing is the safer choice.

- **Trello:** $0 for up to 10 people. Standard for 5 people = $25/mo (annual) or $30/mo (monthly).
- **UpKeep:** 2 paid users = $48/mo. A third paid user breaks the budget.

What Users Say

Reviews checked October 12, 2026. Review sites lean positive because vendors often invite happy customers to post, so the complaints below are weighted more than the star ratings.

- **MaintainX: 4.8/5 on Capterra (1,078 reviews), 4.8 for ease of use.** Reviewers praise the simple interface, fast staff adoption and responsive support. One manager called it "extremely easy to use." Complaints: useful features keep moving to pricier tiers, staff who are not comfortable with computers can find it confusing, and the phone app shows less detail than the web version.
- **Trello: 4.5/5 on Capterra (23,630 reviews), 4.5 for ease of use.** Reviewers say new team members pick it up quickly. Complaints: boards get messy as cards pile up, and reporting is basic without paid add-ons. On the Atlassian Community forum, a user asking about request tracking was told Trello cannot make fields required or enforce approvals; two respondents suggested a dedicated tool instead.
- **UpKeep: 4.6/5 on Capterra (1,331 reviews).** Reviewers like the clean interface and the mobile app for technicians. The most common complaint is cost as more users are added. Others mention occasional bugs and sync delays in the app.

Takeaway: Users back up the recommendation. MaintainX scores highest on ease of use, Trello's weakness is exactly the structure a request system needs, and UpKeep's main complaint is the per-user cost that already strains Dana's budget.

Suggested Next Steps

1. Confirm how many people will close out repairs versus only report them.
2. Sign up for MaintainX Basic and run it alongside texting for 2 weeks.
3. Count how many requests needed photos. If it is regularly more than 5 per month, budget for Essential on annual billing.

Sources

- MaintainX Pricing (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- Trello Pricing (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- UpKeep Pricing (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- MaintainX Reviews, Capterra (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- Trello Reviews, Capterra (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- UpKeep Reviews, Capterra (checked Oct 12, 2026)
- Using Trello for request management, Atlassian Community forum (checked Oct 12, 2026)

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